became my ISRO colleague and succeeded me in heading the Vikas engine project team in France in the late 1970s.

Outside 'the gang', a classmate called K Kalanidhi attracted my attention for his calmness. Those were turbulent times of the anti-Hindi agitation, and Kalanidhi showed great balance of opinion and action. After being elected the joint secretary of the student's union in my third year, I worked to make Kalanidhi the secretary in the fourth year, but he lost the election by a few votes. He died in a bus crash in 2014 while travelling from Chennai to Madurai.

K S Mani, another college mate, who I respected for his unflinching loyalty to fairness beyond caste and creed, came to be known as Avro Mani, after he miraculously survived an Avro aircraft crash in 1971. Mani, then with ISRO, was on his maiden flight, from Trivandrum to Chennai, when the plane crashed into the Meghamalai tea plantation. Mani survived with a broken angle and a few bruises.

The rigour of the course then was such that only twelve of the 120 students passed out of the campus with a first class. I owe it to a handful of great teachers for being one of the high-fliers of Thyagarajar College of Engineering. Amidst the hectic schedule of classes, exams and some wonderful projects, I found time to take part in student activities and got elected as joint secretary of the student union.

It was the peak of the Dravidian movement in Tamil Nadu, but K Kamaraj remained the Chief Minister—and the undisputed king of many hearts. Thyagaraja Chettiar, the founder of our college was keen on bringing Kamaraj to the campus for an interaction with the students, but a section affiliated to the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) laughed at the idea. Their logic was simple: Kamaraj was neither a scholar nor an orator—both perceived prerequisites for a college guest at a time when DMK leaders like C N Annadurai were the faces of intellectualism.

I took upon myself the mission of bringing Kamaraj to the campus. After much effort when I finally met him, Kamaraj gave the same reason as the Dravidian sympathizers had for not having the Chief Minister on the campus. 'What do I, a school dropout, talk to you brilliant students?' he